

Reconstruction Facilitators at Local Level



About HRRP

The Housing Recovery and Reconstruction Platform (HRRP) was launched in December 2015. HRRP took over supporting coordination of the post-earthquake housing reconstruction from the Nepal Shelter Cluster which returned to the pre-earthquake format as a standing cluster. The platform provides coordination support services for the National Reconstruction Authority (NRA), Building and Grant Management and Local Infrastructure (GMALI) Central Level Programme Implementation Units (CLPIUs), other relevant government authorities, and Partner Organizations (POs). HRRP is currently in its fourth phase and will continue its coordination services until July 2021. HRRP is primarily funded by DFID Nepal and CRS Nepal. Other financial contributors and implementing partners include Oxfam, Plan International, and the National Society for Earthquake Technology-Nepal (NSET).

The HRRP works at municipal, district, sub-national, and national levels, providing support primarily to the 14 districts most affected by the earthquake, as well as roving support to the 18 districts moderately affected by the earthquake. The platform has personnel with expertise in general coordination, technical coordination, and information management across all working levels and areas. At national level the platform also has expertise in MEAL, operations, and translation.

Areas of Focus

The HRRP's main areas of focus are:

- Monitoring and documenting the housing reconstruction process.
- Facilitating coordination and experience sharing to support improvements in coverage and quality of socio-technical assistance.
- Supporting collective planning and roll out of additional support for vulnerable households.
- Addressing gaps and duplications.
- Advocacy, communications, and research



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Introduction

The housing reconstruction following the 25 April 2015 Gorkha Earthquake has required a collaborative effort from people across a wide range of government offices and a variety of roles has been done. This document looks to share the varied experiences of mayors, deputy mayors, ward chairpersons, municipal chairpersons, and administrative and operation staff within District Level Project Implementation Units (DLPIUs) working on the reconstruction with the aim of highlighting the importance of their work, the challenges they have faced, and the solutions that have been developed to address these. This document includes representatives from all fourteen of the districts most affected by the earthquake as well as from Khotang, Myagdi, and Lamjung in the eighteen moderately affected districts.

The local elections in Nepal at May, June, and September 2017 were the first the country had in more than 20 years. The election of local officials at ward and municipal level was a positive step for the country, as well as for the reconstruction as it increased the capacity to localize the housing reconstruction efforts to run continually. The National Reconstruction Authority (NRA) at central level has worked to maximize this, including signing a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) ([Nepali, Unofficial English Translation](#)) with all municipalities as part of housing reconstruction reflection workshops held across earthquake affected districts between November 2018 and February 2019. The MoU covers the deployment and management of technical staff and masons at municipal and ward level, as well as providing options for additional staff if required, and provides for the NRA to allocate budget to municipalities for reconstruction activities. The MoU also states that statistics, documents, and documentation related to private housing reconstruction shall be gradually handed over to Municipality and Rural Municipality from the Authority" with support provided by the NRA to municipalities to facilitate this.

This effort to document the experience of mayors, deputy mayors, ward chairpersons, municipal chairpersons, and administrative and operation staff within DLPIUs working on the reconstruction was inspired by a photo series called '[bureaucratics](#)'. Bureaucratics is a comparative photographic study by photographer Jan Banning, of the culture, rituals and symbols of state civil administrations and civil servants across several countries.

'[Bureaucratics](#)' includes the salary of each of the civil servants featured. This has not been replicated in this document, but salaries for the roles represented in this document are roughly as follows:

- Mayor: around 35,000 NPRs (approximately 315 USD) per month
- Deputy Mayor: around 30,000 NPRs (approximately 270 USD) per month
- Ward Chairperson: around 17,800 NPRs (approximately 160 USD) per month
- Municipal Chairperson: around 28,800 NPRs (approximately 260 USD) per month
- Administrative and operation staff within DLPIUs: around 23,500 NPRs (approximately 210 USD) per month

This document does not include the experiences of technical staff working on the reconstruction (engineers, sub-engineers, and assistant sub-engineers) but more information on their experience can be found [HRRP's website](#) and also in [HRRP bulletins](#).



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Durga Kumar Shakya, Chairperson, Netrawati Dabjong Rural Municipality, Dhading



Durga Kumar Shakya at his desk. His key functions include coordinating with other local officials, calling meetings of the assembly & executive body, tabling the agenda in the meeting, and assigning responsibilities to the deputy chief or members.

In Netrawati Dabjong Rural Municipality more than 60% of the housing reconstruction has been completed. However, Mr. Shakya shared that some of the challenges still faced include issues with the availability of NRA technical staff at field level, insufficient door to door technical assistance, inspection process is lengthy, transportation of construction materials is difficult, a high number of non-compliant houses, a lack of monitoring of trained masons in their locality, and banking issues.

He also shared that when the elected officials first came to power, people came to them with their concerns regarding the reconstruction under the impression that the elected officials had full authority on all aspects of the reconstruction. It was challenging to work within this environment when they were still getting to grip with their role in the reconstruction.

In Netrawati Dabjong there are several households who had registered grievances because they had not been identified as eligible for the government's housing reconstruction grant. Mr. Shakya said that "every problem has a solution, and it is very positive that the NRA has announced another round of resurvey and re-verification which will solve this problem".

Subarna Shrestha, Mayor, Shankharapur Municipality, Kathmandu

When the earthquake happened, Subarna threw himself into supporting the recovery and reconstruction as a political leader in the municipality. He feels that this work contributed very positively to his campaign to be mayor. Once elected Subarna worked hard to hear and document the reconstruction challenges that people were facing and worked to solve these in coordination with the DLPIU offices and the NRA.

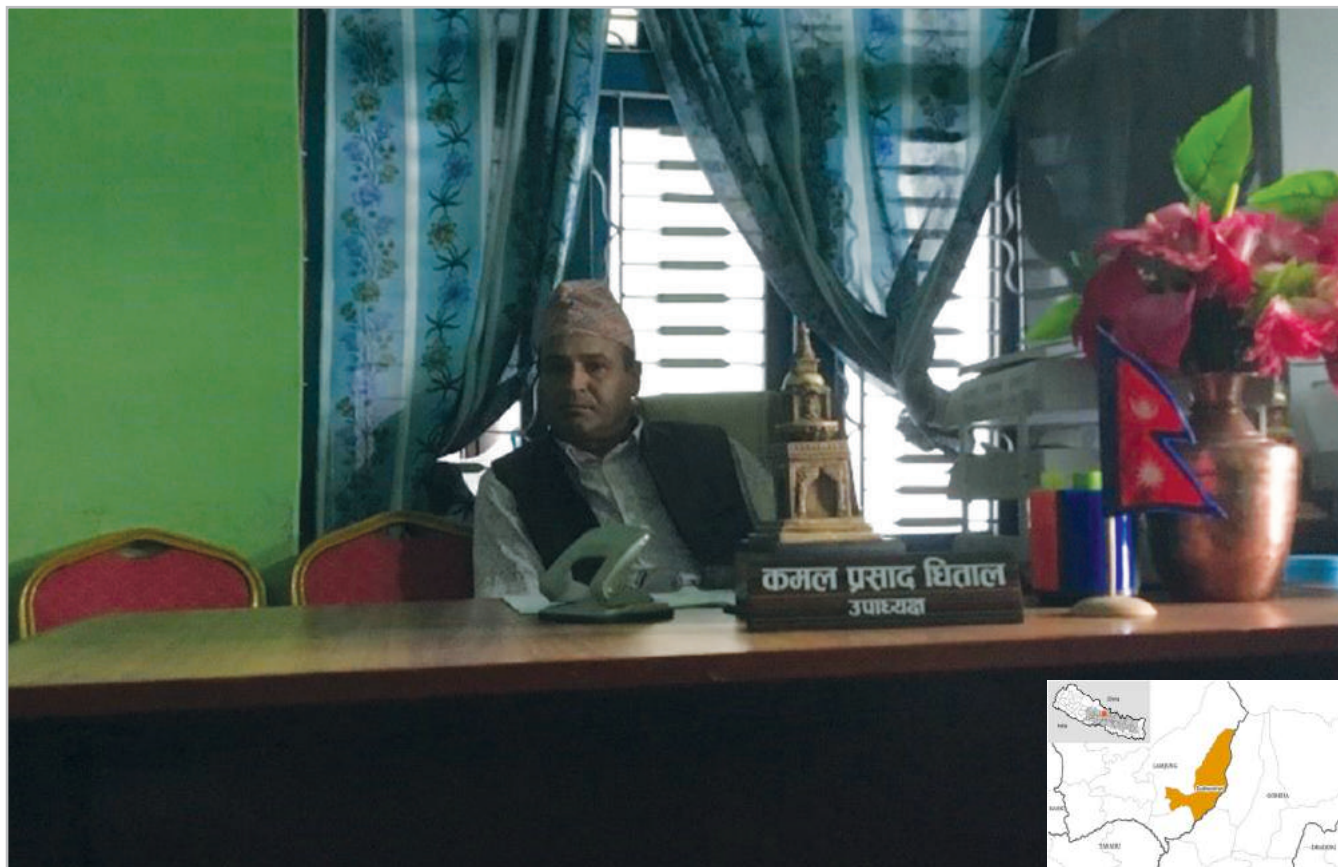
In his role as mayor, Subarna has introduced provisions that waive property taxes for households that rebuild their houses using traditional designs and materials to receive an additional grant of 100,000 NPRs (approximately USD 900). In order to be eligible for this tax waiver, households must keep the height of the house to a maximum of 35 feet, use traditional wooden carved windows and doors, use traditional Newar style bricks, and they must not plaster the outside of the walls. To date, twenty-five houses have been rebuilt in this way.

Mayor Shrestha has also worked to raise awareness of the role of the government's financial assistance; that is to provide a contribution to incentivize the inclusion of earthquake resilient elements, but not to cover the full cost of reconstruction.



Subarna Shrestha at his desk. His key functions include calling, and preparing the agenda for, meetings of the assembly and executive body, assigning responsibilities to the deputy chief or municipality members, overseeing the municipalities fixed and moveable assets, concluding performance contract with concerned authorities, coordinating with other municipalities, provincial government, and federal government, preparing monthly progress reports, monitoring partner organization activities, preparing and managing the municipality budget.

Kamal Prasad Dhital, Vice Chairperson, Dudhpokhari Rural Municipality, Lamjung



Kamal Prasad Dhital at his desk. His key functions include calling, and preparing the agenda for, meetings of the assembly and executive body, assigning responsibilities to municipality members, concluding performance contracts with concerned authorities, coordinating with other municipalities, provincial government, and federal government, preparing monthly progress reports, monitoring development activities, and preparing and managing the municipality budget. He also acts as a coordinator of the judicial committee and takes on the role of acting chief as required.

Kamal was very happy to be elected as the Vice-Chairperson of Dhudhpokhari Rural Municipality and was excited to take on this new role. Before the local election, Kamal worked with his political party to distribute relief items and support the construction of transitional shelters for earthquake affected households.

When Kamal started as Vice-Chairperson he found it difficult to get to grasp with the policies and laws related with the management of the municipality. Due to the lack of office space for municipal office, it was hard to manage work on a day-to-day basis as the municipal officials were not all working together from the same place. The limited number of staff in place with in the municipality also reduced capacity to implement programmes. Given the situation, Kamal was worried that he would not be able to fulfill the election promises he made to the people in the municipality.

Kamal managed to get through that challenging period and shares that things are much improved now. Most important in this was the orientation that municipal officials received from district and federal government on the policies and laws related to their work. They have also established the municipal office and have hired the staff required to implement the municipality works. Kamal feels that he is able to effectively support the people in the municipality and is happy with his work.

Nirmal Ratna Shakya, Ward Chief, Ward No. 16, Lalitpur Metropolitan City, Lalitpur

Before his election as Ward Chief, Nirmal was already contributing to the housing reconstruction as a local political representative. This included conducting surveys with earthquake affected households and raising the issues identified in these surveys with the Lalitpur Metropolitan City. Since his election he has been working to inform households on the NRA's housing reconstruction policies and procedures and support them to implement the relevant technical requirements. He is very proud that his efforts to address issues such as joint ownership or small land plots have results in some households now being able to move forward and start rebuilding their homes.

Nirmal has also facilitated grievance redressed and correction of errors that affected some households and has facilitated others to move from the housing retrofit grant to the housing reconstruction grant. One of the major roles he has undertaken is the mobilization of 185 city volunteers. The city volunteers carry out various types of community work in ward 16. It is planned that these volunteers will be able to provide support to communities following disasters and during the recovery phase.



Nirmal Ratna Shakya at his desk. His key functions include issuing letters of recommendation for migration purposes, obtaining citizenship and, certifying documents related to personal incidents, land, house, reconciliation, and relationships (marriage, birth, family relationship certificates) both in Nepali and English. His work also involves coordinating and assigning responsibilities to the ward members.

Keshav Prasad Dahal, Assistant Executive, GMAI-DLPIU, Kavrepalanchok



Keshav Prasad Dahal at his desk. His key functions include preparing and keeping records of all the administrative documents on reconstruction.

GMAI DLPIU has the main role of coordination in the reconstruction. As this large-scale reconstruction is new to Nepal, it took time to establish the relevant policies and then also took time to adjust and amend policies to address changes in the context. These policy changes have helped to progress the reconstruction but have led to questions from, and confusion amongst, earthquake affected households and various stakeholders.

Keshav's role means that he is the first responder for all grievances raised in the district. Initially, all grievances were dealt with at central level but now some common grievances, such as errors in house owner's name, are dealt with at district level. Keshav is also responsible for mentoring and orienting all office staff on any updates to reconstruction policies and procedures. A major challenge with this is that there are gaps in staffing.

The GMAI DLPIU office recognized that there was a need for ward officials to have more support to manage the grievance process and rolled out a one day orientation programme in all 135 wards of the district to address this. Coordination with reconstruction stakeholders has been promoted and encouraged through regular coordination meetings.

Sandeep Lamsal, Financial Management Specialist, GMaLI-DLPIU, Nuwakot

Sandeep is proud of his work supporting the disbursement of the housing reconstruction and retrofit grants. However, he feels that the process of disbursing the grant on time is the most challenging task that the DLPIU faces. The way that Sandeep, and the DLPIU, have dealt with this challenge is through timely and strong coordination between the technical teams in Building DLPIU and the District Treasury Comptroller Office (DTCO) and the GMaLI DLPIU Account Section.

Despite these efforts there are still sometimes delays in households being able to get their payments from the banks and this can lead to grievances being raised with GMaLI DLPIU. Sandeep and others from GMaLI DLPIU have been meeting with bank officials regarding the delays in payments and this has helped to facilitate the disbursement process and reduce the number of grievances being filed.

Many POs have also provided the housing grant which has caused the issues with double payments to households, where Partner Organizations have duplicated the grant from the GoN. This has been successfully tracked and handled resulting in recovery of 21,600,000 NPRs (approximately USD 193,000) and a further 600,000 NPRs (approximately USD 5,300) is currently being recovered.



Sandeep Lamsal at his desk. His key functions include supporting the District Project Chief and DLPIU Account Section with the distribution of the government's financial assistance for reconstruction, managing all data related to the disbursement of the funds, preparing the DLPIU work plan (which is intended to ensure that households receive their payments in a timely manner), and maintaining all DLPIU financial records required by NRA and GMaLI CLPIU.

Hasta Bahadur Lama, Ward Chief, Ward No. 2, Lisankhu Pakhar Rural Municipality, Sindhupalchok



Hasta Bahadur says that during the initial phase of reconstruction, when the local representatives had not been elected, there were many eligible households missed during the damage assessment. He also feels that there was poor maintenance of records and documentation related to the reconstruction. When he was elected he was very driven to address some of these major issues and get the reconstruction effort in the ward back on track.

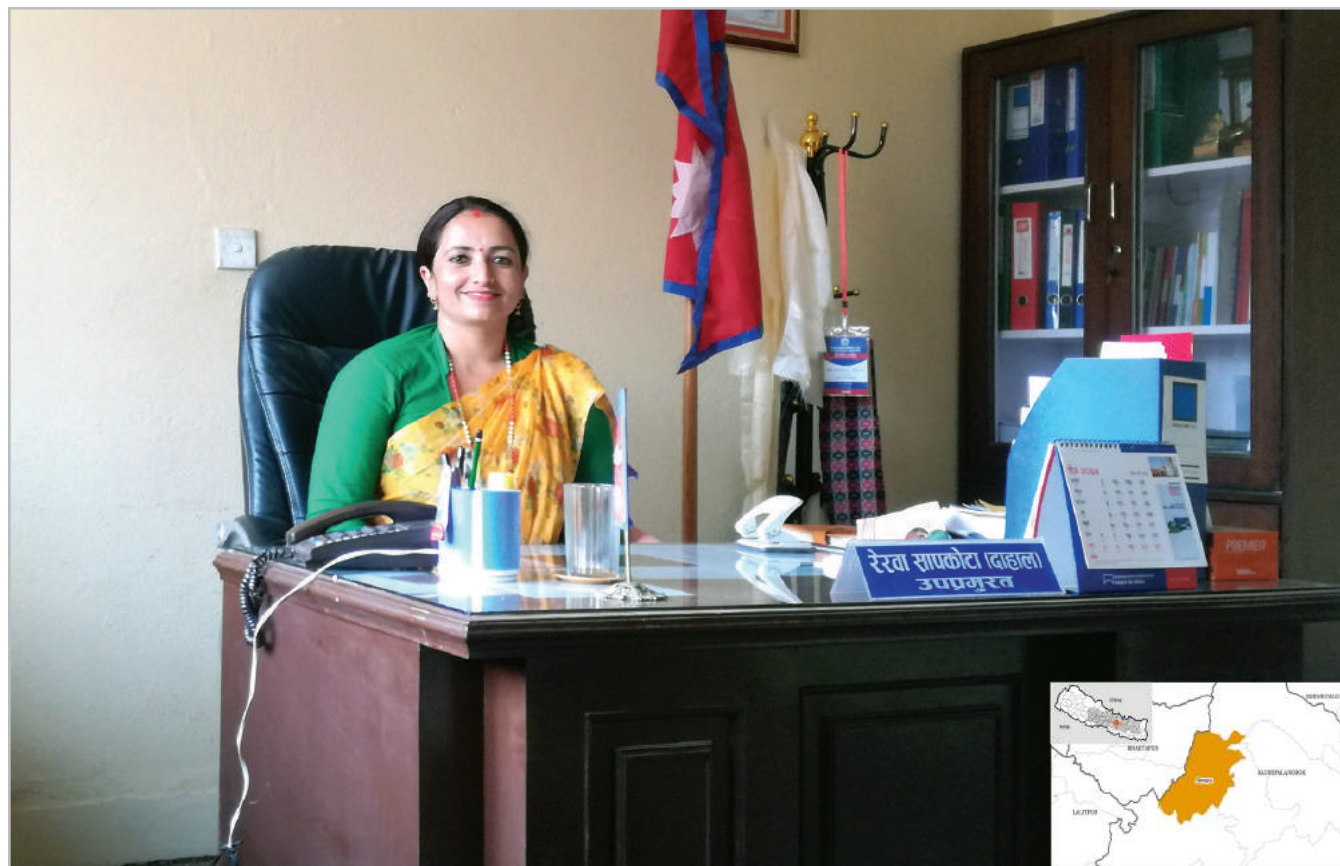
There are eight households in the ward who had taken the first tranche but had not started building and were saying that they did not intend to reconstruct. He scheduled a meeting with them to discuss this and to better understand their situation. Hasta Bahadur shares that following the meeting and the advice that the ward office was able to provide to the households, most of them have now started reconstructing.

Hasta Bahadur Lama at his desk. His key functions include identifying the most pressing issues facing residents in the ward, raising those issues in municipal and district meetings, and planning and identifying the requirements and budget needs of the ward.

Rekha Sapkota (Dahal), Deputy Mayor, Banepa Municipality, Kavrepalanchok

The restructuring of the municipality into fourteen wards, with five officials in each ward responsible for the management of their ward, has facilitated progress across all sectors in development and reconstruction. Rekha feels that one of the main reasons for reconstruction progress is the elected local representatives feel a strong sense of responsibility to the earthquake affected households in Banepa. Having five members present in each ward makes it easier to handle grievances in a timely manner. Monitoring the housing reconstruction is also much easier now because the local bodies are in place and functioning well.

Rekha, along with the municipality, has been involved in the effective mobilization of the technical staff in each ward. The municipality has provisions in place which allow earthquake affected households to pay just 50% of the tax on building permits, construction approval as per plinth area in areas with no road facilities, and prioritizing building permit approval for households who are reconstructing their houses after the earthquake. The municipality has taken major steps to encourage people to reconstruct through effective communication of the reconstruction deadlines and tranche return deadlines.



Rekha Sapkota (Dahal) at her desk. Her key functions include acting as a coordinator of the judicial committee and taking on the role of Acting Chairperson when required.

Bimal KP, Acting Chief, GMaLI-DLPIU, Makwanpur



Bimal KP at his desk. His key functions include coordinating with all reconstruction stakeholders, communicating the key points of guidelines and manual published by the NRA to officials and households, and monitoring the overall reconstruction works at the district.

Bimal KP has been the Acting Chief of GMaLI DLPIU in Makwanpur for two months but has been working on the reconstruction for two years. He previously worked as an engineer with GMaLI DLPIUs in Lalitpur and Bhaktapur. As Acting Chief, Bimal is responsible for all areas of reconstruction including housing, school buildings, community buildings, public buildings, and temples. Bimal has been leading the organization for the district reconstruction facilitation and coordination meetings and has taken responsibility of ensuring that all stakeholders are actively engaged. This includes banks, government agencies, and Partner Organizations (POs). Bimal has been working to further the frequency and quality of two-way communication between the local governments and the district government agencies. To facilitate this, he has been directly involved in field visits, seminars, and public hearing programmes across different municipalities and wards in the district.

Bimal is currently working to implement an interaction programme in every municipality in the district to provide information and support to landless households. He shares that some major issues have been addressed through solutions provided by central level government, for example the policy to provide up to 200,000 NPRs to landless households for the purchase of land and the development of technical manuals and guidelines. Bimal shares that retrofitting is the major reconstruction issue in the district.

Kaji Bahadur Lama, Ward Chairperson, Ward No. 3, Lisankhu Pakhar Rural Municipality, Sindhupalchok

During the early days of the reconstruction, the biggest challenge Kaji Bahadur Lama and the ward office faced was convincing people to construct earthquake resilient houses and follow the National Building Code (NBC). The ward is in a remote part of the rural municipality and it was difficult to get information to everyone. To create awareness of the importance and benefit of earthquake resilient construction, Kaji Bahadur initiated a door to door information campaign.

Another major challenge faced in the ward is dealing with grievances. The ward was completely missed in the initial damage assessment survey and he has dedicated a lot of time advocating for a resurvey since being elected as Ward Chairperson. As part of this he travelled to the Central Level National Reconstruction Authority offices in Singha Durbar to meet with the concerned personnel. He was beginning to lose hope but has been boosted by the recent deployment of engineers in the ward under the current round of resurveys.



Kaji Bahadur Lama at his desk. His key functions include conducting meetings with ward members to identify the needs and issues of the ward, planning and identifying budget needs, participating in district and municipal meetings, and tabling the needs of the ward in those meetings.

Nabaraj KC, Rural Municipality Chairperson, Champadevi Rural Municipality, Okhaldhunga



Nabaraj KC at his desk. His key functions include coordinating with all Ward Chairperson and the central level government on municipal development plans and activities, allocating budget to all wards based on needs, and the overall development of the municipality.

After Nabaraj KC was elected, the biggest challenge he faced was convincing households to construct earthquake resilient houses, especially as Champadevi is in a rural part of the district. He found that people weren't rebuilding, or weren't interested to rebuild, earthquake resilient houses because they felt the 300,000 NPRs government grant is not enough to cover the cost of the materials required and they did not have access to skilled masons who can build such type of houses.

Recognizing that people needed additional information on safer construction, Nabaraj KC initiated a door to door campaign to meet with households. He carried out the visits with the technical staff felt it was a successful activity that had an impact on how people chose to rebuild.

The other major issue that he has faced is addressing grievances. The ward where he lives was completely missed during the first round of resurvey to address grievances. As a result, he has been advocating for resurvey in that area since he was elected. He travelled to Singha Durbar to meet the concerned personnel at central level regarding the resurvey. The NRA has recently deployed engineers in the ward for resurvey, and he is hopeful that the issue can be resolved soon.

Jhal Prasad Devkota, Ward Chairperson, Ajirkot Rural Municipality, Ward No. 5, Muchowk, Gorkha

Jhal Prasad spent some years working in Gulf States in the early 90s and when he returned in 1996, he was determined to contribute to the development of his community. He spent many years involved in social work in Muchowk and when the earthquake hit in 2015 he was actively involved in the emergency response. There were no local elected representatives at that time, so he tried to support coordination with the Government of Nepal, Red Cross, and other relief agencies.

After he was elected Ward Chairperson, Jhal Prasad immediately started to try and provide public services from the ward office but there was a lot of confusion about how local government should and would function initially. Because the housing reconstruction is the biggest issue in the area, the ward office has been focused on this. Jhal Prasad shared that there is still a number of vulnerable households that being left behind and there are not enough employment opportunities for people in Muchowk.

Jhal Prasad has been working to address grievances and has taken part in many site visits with the NRA DLPIU engineers and other ward members to document the reality of reconstruction for households. He has also developed a multi-sectoral, inclusive development plan for the whole ward covering roads, public infrastructure, water supplies, school buildings, and strengthened public service delivery.



Jhal Prasad Devkota at his desk. His key functions include delivering public services such as recommendation letters for access to government services, issuing birth, marriage, and death certificates, identification and prioritization of development activities. He is also involved in reconstruction activities such as identification of eligible households, facilitation to resolve issues related to reconstruction, providing recommendations, monitoring reconstruction progress, mobilization of technical staff, and conducting public hearings.

Subit Kumar Sunuwar, Ward Secretary, Ward No. 2, Lisankhu Pakhar Rural Municipality, Sindhupalchok



In the reconstruction process, he has been the de-facto focal person for reconstruction and he is actively involved in disseminating information from district and central NRA to households, mostly by drafting notices and through meeting people visiting the ward office.

He shares that before he got posted to the ward office, the files were poorly maintained, and the ward office was struggling to communicate with households. When he was deployed to the office three years back, he has effectively maintained the records, and attended to households' needs however possible. This includes his work to follow up on the tranche status of individual households.

Subit has also been working on drafting recommendation letters for households with regard to grievances that have been addressed by the ward level grievance management committee, for the NRA engineers' attendance, and other letters containing information as required by the NRA.

Subit Kumar Sunuwar at his desk. His key functions include day to day operation of the ward, drafting the meeting minutes of the ward level meetings, managing of the records in the ward, and managing the ward financial activities.

Ashok Bista, Chief Administrative Officer, Tadi Rural Municipality, Nuwakot

The post-earthquake reconstruction is something that is very challenging for everyone involved.

In some areas in Tadi Rural Municipality it was not possible for people to reconstruct in the same place as the land was found to be hazardous during the geo-hazard risk assessment conducted by the National Reconstruction Authority.

We had the very difficult task of supporting these households to relocate and to build on their new land. There has been some success though and 75 households from Urleni (ward no. 1) have relocated to safe land in Budune (ward no. 3). The process to relocate other at-risk villages to safe land is ongoing.



Ashok Bista at his desk. He is responsible for all work associated with the management of the rural municipality office including administration, finance / accounting, and human resources.

Yam Nath Giri, Monitoring and Evaluation Specialist, GMaLI-DLPIU, Lalitpur



Yam Nath Giri at his desk. His key functions include developing and overseeing the project level Monitoring & Evaluation (M&E) plan, reviewing M&E methods, designing M&E tools, carrying out training needs assessments, ensuring quality control of M&E outputs, supporting the design and field testing of monitoring methodology, sourcing data and information from the Project Management Unit and other agencies for specific M&E needs, and handling tasks related to fiduciary risk monitoring. Yam Nath also cooperates and coordinates with the Socio Communication Specialist for the design, quality, development, and completion of all assessments, analytical reports, case studies, and success stories.

Lalitpur has both urban and rural areas that were affected by the earthquake, adding to the complexity of the reconstruction. Approximately 30% of affected households have rebuilt so far, which is positive but is not at the same level as other districts. Land issues and the high number of multi-ownership houses are some of the issues impacting on progress. Many people are building one or two room houses, even if there are more than 4 or 5 family members, just to access the government's financial assistance. Most continue to live in their earthquake damaged house, and some are using the one or two room houses as a shed for livestock. This shows that we are not getting the expected results and people are not moving towards earthquake resistant houses.

After being appointed, Yam Nath organised meeting with Partner Organizations (POs) working in the district. As a result, we found out that some POs were working without approval from the NRA. Recognizing the risks associated with this Yam Nath, with support from HRRP, visited houses that were constructed by (POs). This highlighted multiple duplications with households receiving the government's financial assistance as well as receiving a house and/or financial assistance from a PO. Yam Nath has been leading the process to recover the duplicated funds and to date almost 11.5 million NPRs (approximately USD 103,500) has been recovered and the process is underway to recover a further 4 million NPRs (approximately USD 36,000).

Nirajan Jangam, Ward Chairperson, Ward No. 8, Dhulikhel Municipality, Kavrepalanchok

Being elected as a local representative comes with the weight of the high hopes and expectations of the people you represent. Nirajan has been working to support people in a flexible and effective way, particularly in relation to the recovery and reconstruction. The recovery is a complicated and challenging process and dealing with grievances has been very difficult but Nirajan feels that he and his team's focus on coordination and team work has made it possible to move forward in a positive way.

Nirajan has placed a strong emphasis on information management to ensure that data is properly collected and analyzed to facilitate the housing reconstruction. Based on the data, he has been able to request required support from related reconstruction bodies on time, be it sending the non-compliance cases to DSE or raising landless issues at the municipality. With technical assistance to the households being the top most priority in reconstruction, he has provided transportation facilities to the ward technical people, so they can reach every household on time. This facility was inspired by his ideology of mobile services to reach those in need. This has led to a higher rate of reconstruction progress in his ward.



Nirajan Jangam at his desk. His key functions include preparing the work plan and budget for the ward, collecting and maintaining household data such as number of houses and demographic details, maintaining records of public property, conducting child and environment friendly programmes, carrying out market monitoring, ensuring smooth supply of essential goods and services, working on building code implementation, and preparing monthly progress reports. He is also responsible for issuing letters of recommendation for obtaining citizenship and certifying documents related to personal incidents, land ownership, family relationship, marriage, and birth certificates.

Srijana Sunuwar, Computer Operator, DLPIU-Building, Okhaldhunga



Srijana Sunuwar at her desk. Her key functions include supporting municipal officials and technical staff with dissemination of information to households, maintaining records and files, drafting letters related to reconstruction issues.

When Srijana was first posted to the DLPIU office in Okhaldhunga, the files had been very poorly maintained. There was also no Management Information System (MIS) expert in place so she had limited support. This was very challenging but now the MIS expert is in place Srijana works to support them and this has been positive.

Srijana has now been in the office for three years and has managed over that time to effectively maintain the inspection and tranche disbursement records and is responsible for updating the technical staff on the data when required.

Srijana also shares information on new / updated policy and guidelines for the housing reconstruction with municipal officials and technical staff so that they can apply this in their work and disseminate relevant and up to date information to households. Srijana accesses the information on new or updated policy and guidelines through emails and letters from the Building Central Level Programme Implementation Unit (CLPIU) as well as through her own research and networks, e.g. checking the NRA website, DLPIU staff Facebook groups, etc.

Purna Bahadur Dahal, Chairperson, Arughat Rural Municipality, Gorkha

Purna has long been an active political leader at district level. After the earthquake he was engaged in relief work at village level and was also a member of the District Disaster Risk Committee (DDRC). Purna finds one of the main challenges faced in reconstruction was how to effectively support vulnerable and marginalised households to rebuild their homes. To address this, Purna led the development and roll out of a municipal revolving fund. The first loans from the revolving fund were distributed in February 2018. To date 32 households have used the revolving fund and 22 households have already returned their loan to the revolving fund basket. So far, Aarughat RM is the only municipality that has successfully rolled out this initiative.

Purna launched reconstruction helpdesks and deployed a municipal reconstruction focal person with support from POs. This focal person is responsible for organising ward level coordination meetings and feeding the issues raised and key points from these meetings back to the municipality. They also provide support to the technical staff.

Some of the challenges that still need to be addressed in the municipality include the reconstruction process for landless households and households affected by the construction of the Budhigandaki hydropower plant, grievances, relocation and resettlement, and rising levels of debt. Purna hopes that coordination and collaboration with central and district government will lead to solutions.



Purna Bahadur Dahal at his desk. His key functions include coordinating with all Ward Chairpersons, and provincial and central level government on municipal development plans and activities, allocating budget to all wards based on needs, and the overall development of the municipality.

Ramesh Kumar Basnet, Mayor, Manthali Municipality, Ramechhap



Ramesh Kumar Basnet at his desk. His key functions include coordinating activities between the wards, organising meetings of the municipal assembly, coordinating municipality development activities, preparing and managing the municipal budget, coordinating with other municipalities, and provincial and federal government.

Ramesh was excited about taking on his new role as Mayor of Manthali Municipality but at the beginning there were many challenges, including that there was no office space available for newly elected local officials. There was also a lack of staff in the municipality, an issue that continues. Ramesh found that many of the laws at local level were old and out of date and needed to be updated and improved. There are several new laws currently waiting to be endorsed for the effective implementation of municipality works. These include laws related to support for landless households, Disaster Risk Management in the municipality, and the utilization of the municipality's natural resources such as stone, sand, and timber.

In Ramechhap, there are approximately 50,000 households eligible for the government's housing reconstruction grant. The housing reconstruction has been progressing well but there are issues remaining in relation to urban reconstruction. These include issues related to right of way, a household living on Guthi land and a household living on Ailani (government) land. Ramesh hopes that strong coordination with all urban wards, as well as regular meetings with households and technical staff in urban areas will lead to resolution of these issues.

Deepa Bohara (Dahal), Chairperson, Sunkoshi Rural Municipality, Sindhuli

Sunkoshi Rural Municipality was most affected by the earthquake. Many households are eligible for the retrofit grant but as most houses are stone and mud mortar masonry the municipality does not feel retrofitting will be an appropriate solution. Deepa shares that retrofitting is too expensive and technically difficult, so the municipality's preference is to demolish those houses and provide full housing reconstruction grant. Deepa has a mixed experience with the NRA DLPIU engineers with some demonstrating real dedication to their work, while others rarely showing up in their wards. The municipality has been supporting the engineers as much as possible, including allowing flexible working hours and leave plans, providing office space, and supporting with field visits.

Deepa feels, there are gaps in communication that need to be bridged, especially for households who have completed reconstruction but have only received the first tranche from the government. Deepa shared that many households rebuilt immediately after the earthquake and do not have the required documentation and photos to justify approval for the second and third tranches. People are unaware of the policy and guidelines for applying corrections and so they have effectively stalled within the reconstruction grant process. Deepa feels that improved file management and tracking would allow household, ward and municipal officials to access information on tranche disbursement in a timely manner which would make the reconstruction easier.



Deepa Bohara (Dahal) at her desk. Her key functions include coordinating with local and provincial level government, organizing meetings with Ward Chairpersons to discuss the development plans and activities of all wards and the municipality as a whole, preparing the municipality budget, preparing monthly progress reports, and monitoring activities of partner organizations working in the municipality.

Sagar Acharya, Chief, GMaLI-DLPIU, Khotang



Sagar Acharya at his desk. His key functions include coordination with government counterparts and partner organizations in the district, organizing coordination meetings, conducting monitoring visits to see the progress in private housing reconstruction, addressing grievances, sharing reconstruction issues and challenges and resolving them in consultation with DLPIU Building and central NRA, sharing and disseminating reconstruction policies and guidelines to all stakeholders, preparing monthly progress reports on reconstruction, and reporting to central level.

Sagar has been the GMaLI DLPIU Chief in Khotang for just over one year. He was transferred from Dolakha, so he has a range of experience on reconstruction in Nepal. Sagar feels that the reconstruction progress in the fourteen most affected districts is much better than in the eighteen moderately affected districts.

Some of the issues affecting reconstruction in Khotang are that the GMaLI DLPIU office was established a relatively long time after the earthquake, the technical staff were deployed after many people had already rebuilt, and there has only been one Partner Organisation (PO) supporting reconstruction in Khotang and they only work in one municipality. Sagar felt that in Dolakha the reconstruction support provided by POs played an important role in speeding up the reconstruction process.

Sagar has found that there are lots of households in Khotang who do not want to rebuild their house but are also not willing to return the first tranche of the government's housing reconstruction grant. For households who are eligible for the government's retrofit grant, Sagar feels that it will be very important for them to have access to technical support. This will require training the inspection engineers on the retrofit guidelines and training masons on the implementation of retrofitting. Sagar very much appreciates the role of local officials in speeding up the reconstruction process.

Yubaraj Kharel, Project Chief, GMaLI-DLPIU, Okhaldhunga

Yubaraj Kharel has been working as the Project Chief of the GMaLI DLPIU in Okhaldhunga for the last three years. Initially progress with the housing reconstruction in the district was slow. However, just over 70% of eligible households in the district have now received the third tranche the government's housing reconstruction grant. Yubaraj feels that this progress is as a result of GMaLI DLPIU's close coordination with all government officials and Partner Organizations (POs). He shares that grievances have been the most challenging reconstruction issue he has faced. He has conducted regular coordination meetings with local government to support grievance processing and minimize the number and impact of grievances. Another issue that has been addressed is the mismatch between partnership agreement numbers that came up in about 700 cases in the district. All 700 files were brought to a central NRA MIS expert to be dealt with. An additional 72 complex errors in PA number mismatches were solved by bringing a central MIS expert to Okhaldhunga to process these cases.

Yubaraj has been conducting regular joint visits with the NRA DLPIU engineers and has been holding regular meetings with all municipalities. He shares that these visits and meetings have contributed to addressing gaps and solving problems. He also initiated a series of joint monitoring visits with the District Support Engineer (DSE) and technical staff to address non-compliances. This has led to a number of pending tranche payments being processed.



Yubaraj Kharel at his desk. His key functions include coordination with government and reconstruction partner organizations in the district, conducting coordination meetings, monitoring private housing reconstruction, sharing reconstruction progress issues and challenges with central level, and disseminating policy and guidelines related to reconstruction to all stakeholders.

Ghanshyam Raut, Mayor, Dudhauri Municipality, Sindhuli



Ghanshyam Raut at his desk. His key functions include calling meetings of the assembly and executive body, tabling the agenda in the meetings, assigning responsibilities to the deputy chief and other members, coordinating with local, provincial, and federal government, preparing monthly progress reports, and monitoring partner organization activities.

The local elections were held after the earthquake and reconstruction had started when the local officials took up office. However, there were many challenging issues that had to be dealt with by the local officials immediately after they took up their roles. For example, most households were dwelling on Ailani land (government land) and there is only one bank in the municipality which made it difficult for some households to access their reconstruction grant. Ghanshyam feels that the process to support households through the reconstruction process, and to provide them with the technical support required to ensure safer construction, has been consistently improving. He feels that this is the reason that the reconstruction in the municipality is coming in to the last phase and will be completed soon. The municipality has trained the ward and municipal staff so that they are able to help households in any way possible and particularly with regard to the reconstruction process in general and the documentation required receiving the tranches.

To ensure strong coordination with the wards, Ghanshyam conducts a monthly meeting at municipal level where each ward presents the overall status report for their ward, highlights progress, and shares challenges and issues that have been encountered. Following these meetings, the municipality works with the wards to develop solutions and plans for implementing these wherever possible.

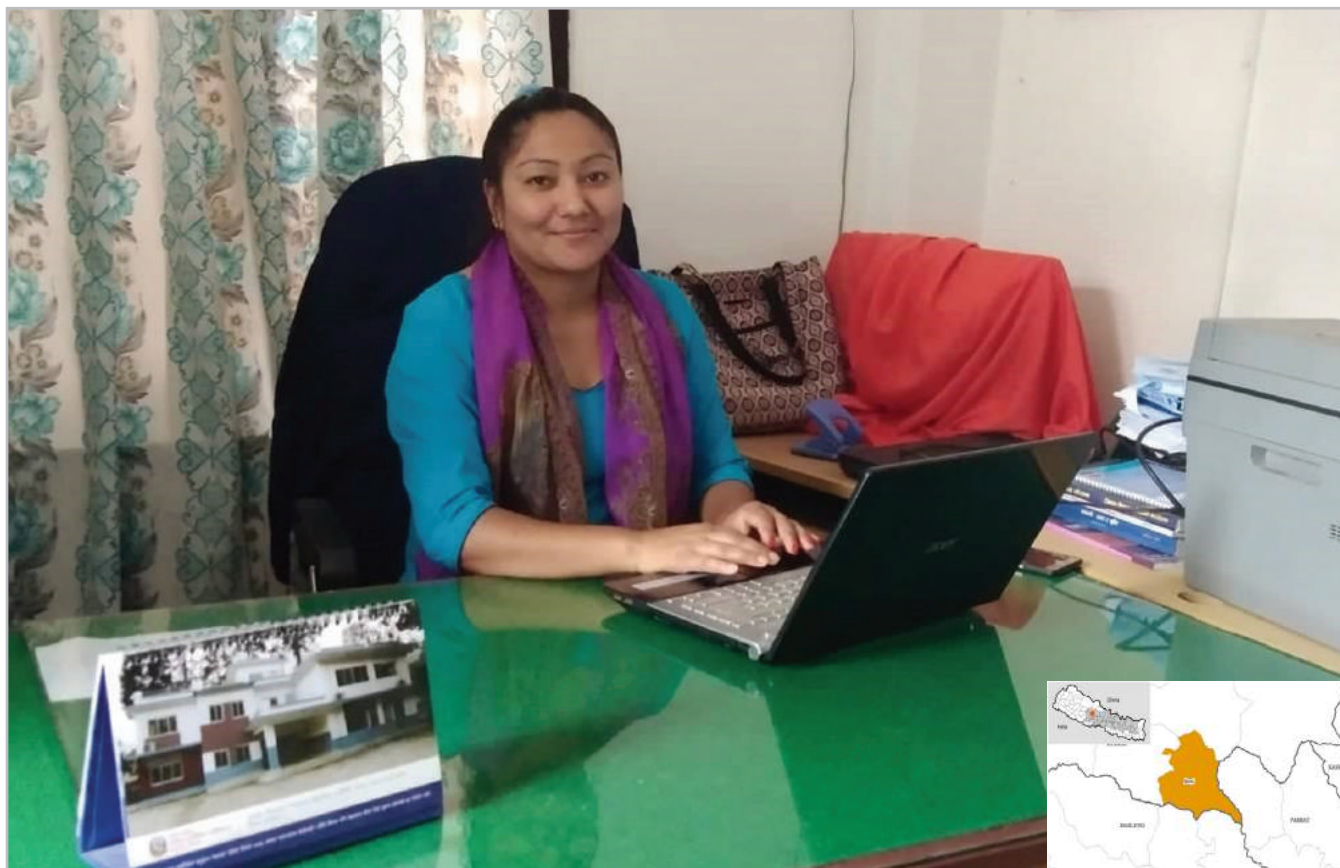
Gyanmaya Dangol, Deputy Mayor, Tokha Municipality, Kathmandu

After the 2015 earthquake, Gyanmaya worked to clear debris and supported construction of temporary shelters. She feels that this work in the immediate aftermath of the earthquake contributed to her election and since becoming Deputy Mayor she has stepped up to lead work on post-earthquake recovery. Gyanmaya's own house, which had been built from sun dried bricks, collapsed in the earthquake. Having seen the damage caused by the earthquake, Gyanmaya and many others in the municipality feel that they need to build stronger, safer houses that comply with the building code to avoid similar disasters in future. Gyanmaya has already completed reconstruction of her own house, and she made sure to work in consultation with an engineer and to invest in a code compliant structure. Gyanmaya meets with the NRA DLPIU engineers on a regular basis and this provides her with the opportunity to hear directly from them about reconstruction issues and issues they face in carrying out their work. Initially a lack of trained human resources impeded reconstruction progress, but mason training has been carried out to address this. The municipality has adopted new policies, approved by the Municipal Council Assembly, which provide for household that are reconstructing to get house design approval at a reduced price and allow for a rebate in property tax. The municipality has also conducted awareness raising activities to support housing reconstruction. Gyanmaya feels that this combination of initiatives has been very successful.



Gyanmaya Dangol at her desk. Her key functions include coordinating with local, provincial, and federal government, preparing monthly progress reports, monitoring partner organization activities, carry out market monitoring to ensure smooth supply of essential goods and services, and preparing and managing the municipal budget. She also acts as a coordinator of the judicial committee and takes on the role of acting chief when required.

Dil Maya Bitalu Chhetri, Computer Operator, DLPIU-GMaLI, Myagdi



Dil Maya Bitalu Chhetri at her desk. Her key functions include supporting the data entry and recommendation process for tranche payments, data correction, preparing, processing, and filing official correspondence, supporting coordination and communication within the GMaLI DLPIU team and with all stakeholders, providing support to households who require services from GMaLI DLPIU, and taking part in field visits to carry out progress monitoring and meet with earthquake affected communities.

Dil Maya has been working as a computer operator in the GMaLI DLPIU office in Myagdi since July 2018 and prior to this she worked in the District Development Committee (DDC) in Myagdi.

Dil Maya shares that even though there are lots of challenges faced in the reconstruction, she feels it is the responsibility of everyone working to support housing reconstruction to collectively find solutions rather than working in isolation and / or blaming others. Dil shares that one of the challenges she has faced in carrying out her work is that a lot of data from before she started is not available, in particular migration of data from the District Coordination Committee (DCC) to GMaLI DLPIU did not go smoothly.

Dil shares that the part of her work she enjoys most is the time she spends conducting field visits and meeting with earthquake affected households. It gives her the opportunity to see the real situation that households face and to hear their experiences directly. Most people that Dil meets with are concerned about houses constructed before the mobilisation of technical staff in the field. They are not sure if they will be able to get the remaining tranches or not and Dil feels that this issue needs to be settled properly to remove confusion and encourage households to move forward with applying corrections.

Dhurba Gaida, Chief, DLPIU-GMaLI, Bhaktapur

Dhurba has been Chief of GMALI DLPIU Bhaktapur for one year. During this time, he has led the development of a web application (recentitsolutions.com) to publish the list of households eligible for the government's financial assistance for reconstruction and to disseminate information on the distribution of the financial assistance as quickly as possible.

Dhurba has actively participated in public hearing programmes, met with households to hear grievances, initiated broadcast of information and public notices through radio and newspapers, and facilitated the resurvey and verification process for unresolved grievances.

Dhurba has also worked in close coordination with central level NRA and GMALI CLPIU to resolve issues related to households living in the border area of the district who had not been able to receive the reconstruction grant as they were deemed to be constructing in the neighbouring district.

One of the major reconstruction challenges in Bhaktapur is where multiple households eligible for the government housing reconstruction grant live in the same house. Many ward level meetings have been held to try and sort out these issues, but it has been difficult to get municipal approval for the building design in these cases.



Dhurba Gaida at his desk. His key functions include coordinating with all reconstruction stakeholders, communicating the key points of guidelines and manuals published by the NRA to local officials and households, monitoring housing reconstruction activities in the district, and furthering cooperation and coordination with central level agencies to create an enabling environment for the housing reconstruction.

Srijana Lama, Vice Chairperson, Naukunda Rural Municipality, Rasuwa



Srijana Lama at her desk. Her key functions include calling, and preparing the agenda for, meetings of the assembly and executive body, assigning responsibilities to municipality members, concluding performance contracts with concerned authorities, coordinating with other municipalities, provincial government, and federal government, preparing monthly progress reports, monitoring development activities, and preparing

After the earthquake, Srijana worked with a local Non-Governmental Organisation to collect information on households who had been affected by the earthquake and supported distribution of relief items. Srijana continued in this work until the local elections and found that this gave her a great platform to run for election. After being elected, reconstruction has been the first agenda point in every meeting of the Rural Municipality's Executive Body, and Srijana is responsible for circulating decisions taken in these meetings to the DLPIU for implementation at district level. Srijana is also working to raise awareness about the housing reconstruction process at community level. The rural municipality has established helpdesks in different areas and circulated information on the reconstruction process through local community leaders and representatives. Srijana finds this work very rewarding, especially as Naukunda Rural Municipality had made the most progress on housing reconstruction out of all earthquake affected municipalities.

One of the challenges faced in Naukanda was that initially the technical staff were not staying in the areas they had been assigned to. Srijana raised this issue at Executive Committee meetings and pushed for the Ward Chairpersons to be responsible for the monitoring of technical staff. This was agreed, and the NRA also circulated the same approach about one month later. Srijana has found that this approach has improved the presence of technical staff.

Tanka Jirel, Chairperson, Jiri Municipality, Dolakha

Tanka found the reconstruction process very difficult initially as it seemed that the required policies, systems, guidelines, and administrative processes were not in place. These are now in place and the housing construction has progressed well.

There are still reconstruction issues though, including that most masons working in Jiri are from Rautahat, Kalikot, Nepaljung, Dang, etc. as the people from Jiri that received masons training from NGOs are no longer working in construction and delays with release of tranche payments at the banks. Inspection engineers have reportedly been processing files for tranche release in a selective or biased way. Tanka has discussed this issue directly with the inspection engineers during municipal meetings and through one-to-one meetings with inspection engineers. He has also informed Building DLPIU of the issue. The inspection engineers recently went on strike over issues with pay and work conditions which led to almost a month of no progress on the housing reconstruction.

On a positive note, Tanka shares that some NGOs have approached the municipality to offer support to households eligible for the retrofit grant. Tanka is relieved that the final phase of resurvey and verification is taking place at the moment but is concerned that the reconstruction process will be never ending if new claims for the housing reconstruction grant continue to arise.



Tanka Jirel at his desk. His key functions include collaborating with local bodies, calling meetings of the assembly and executive body, tabling the agenda for meetings, assigning responsibilities to ward and municipality officers, monitoring monthly progress, preparing and managing the municipality budget, allocation of rate of construction materials, and coordinating with central government to work as a bridge between local and central government.

Gita Satyal, Deputy Mayor, Lalitpur Metropolitan City, Lalitpur



After becoming the Deputy Mayor, Gita Satyal has been actively involved in reconstruction activities such as coordinating with different stakeholders, grievance handling and reconstructing severely damaged infrastructures, especially temples, public buildings that are listed in the cultural heritage sites. The reconstruction of some of the cultural heritage structures in Patan Durbar Square listed in the World Heritage Sites such as Krishna Temple, Char Narayan Temple, Bhairav Temple has been completed. Gita, along with Lalitpur Metropolitan City (LMC) has been actively involved in addressing issues and challenges in reconstruction through dialogues and feedback collection mechanism. The LMC has enforced building code implementation and encouraged households to comply building code while constructing houses. The LMC has provision that waive property taxes on the building permits to earthquake affected households.

Gita shares that, Disaster Risk Reduction (DRR) team has been formed at the Metropolitan level and Disaster Management Committee at each ward. First Aid and Rescue training has been provided to two volunteers from each ward and 100 volunteers have been prepared in ward 16 to support in times of disaster. Gita also as a deputy of Grievance Handling Committee has been involved in public hearing programs to disseminate information on reconstruction.

Gita Satyal at her desk. Her key functions include coordinating with local, provincial and federal government, preparing and managing the municipal budget, preparing monthly progress report. She also acts as a coordinator of the judicial committee and takes on the role of acting chief when required.

Conclusion

There are 96 Mayors, 96 Deputy Mayors, 2,594 Ward Chairpersons, 186 Municipal Chairpersons, and 682 Administrative and Operation staff within District Level Programme Implementation Units (DLPIUs) across the 32 earthquake affected districts. This document provides a glimpse of the reconstruction experiences of just a small number of these people, but it is hoped that this will draw attention to their work and the importance of their role in the housing reconstruction. Whilst the Mayors, Deputy Mayors, Ward Chairpersons, Municipal Chairpersons, and Administrative and Operation staff within the DLPIUs who shared their experiences in this document work across a wide range of contexts, there are many similarities in what they have shared. For example, the feeling of being confused and unsure how to proceed in the period immediately after being appointed / elected in their role and the positive impact that orientation and training had in addressing this. Many of the stories demonstrate the initiative that is being taken at local and district level to try different approaches and activities to try to address the challenges that are faced.

With the number of Partner Organisations (POs) supporting the reconstruction already reducing, and set to reduce further, the local and district level officials and staff working to facilitate the reconstruction effort will increasingly be the only actors working on this. There is clearly capacity at these levels to take on the technical assistance activities which will be essential to pushing towards the completion of the housing reconstruction. This is an opportunity and one that, if taken, could have a positive knock on effect on the development of local level government in the long term. Taking this opportunity will depend upon further investment in strengthening local government leadership of the post-earthquake reconstruction, further delegation of authority to local government, and continuous support from central government. This will require the following:

- Implementation of the eleven points under the MoU (Nepali, Unofficial English Translation) signed between NRA and local government to drive reconstruction from ground level and to expedite the reconstruction process. Progress has been made in some areas, for example there are municipalities and wards that are directly mobilizing technical staff. However, the deployment of human resources, allocation of budget to municipalities for reconstruction activities at local level, and handover of information management (with associated support for human resources and equipment) has yet to be implemented. The NRA is preparing to deploy social mobilizers, engineers, and mobile masons as mobile technical assistance teams but it is not clear when these staff will be deployed, and they will only be deployed in the eleven most affected districts (not including the three districts in the Kathmandu Valley).
- More delegation of authority and responsibility to local government for reconstruction activities such as support to vulnerable households, and relocation and resettlement. This could contribute to localizing the reconstruction efforts further and may provide space for increased decision making at local level which could speed up some areas of the reconstruction.
- As part of the MoU (Nepali, Unofficial English Translation) signed between NRA and local government, all municipalities were required to prepare a reconstruction action plan in coordination with the NRA. These reconstruction action plans are in place but will have an impact only if local authorities are supported to monitor and adjust the plans as required. Supporting realistic and effective planning at local level could have a positive impact on the overall planning and budgeting for the reconstruction.

- As mentioned above, one of the common threads through all the stories in this document is the positive impact that training and orientation has had on people's experience in their work. Given the complexity of the reconstruction work, and the reality that policies and guidelines will need to adapt and adjust over time, training and orientation cannot be viewed as a one-off activity. The people at local and district level that are facilitating the reconstruction need to have access to training and orientation opportunities on a continuous basis.





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